

## CAREER PATHS

Probationary firefighters usually start their careers working at a local fire department, each of which recruits on a local basis. Other employers include airports and the military services. Progressing to senior roles depends on gaining qualifications in areas such as advanced firefighting techniques, emergency medical technology, and disaster management (coordinating the response to disasters).

**TRAINEE** Your personal and physical attributes are more important than academic results, but a good general education is useful. To gain experience before applying, you can volunteer in support roles with a local fire station.

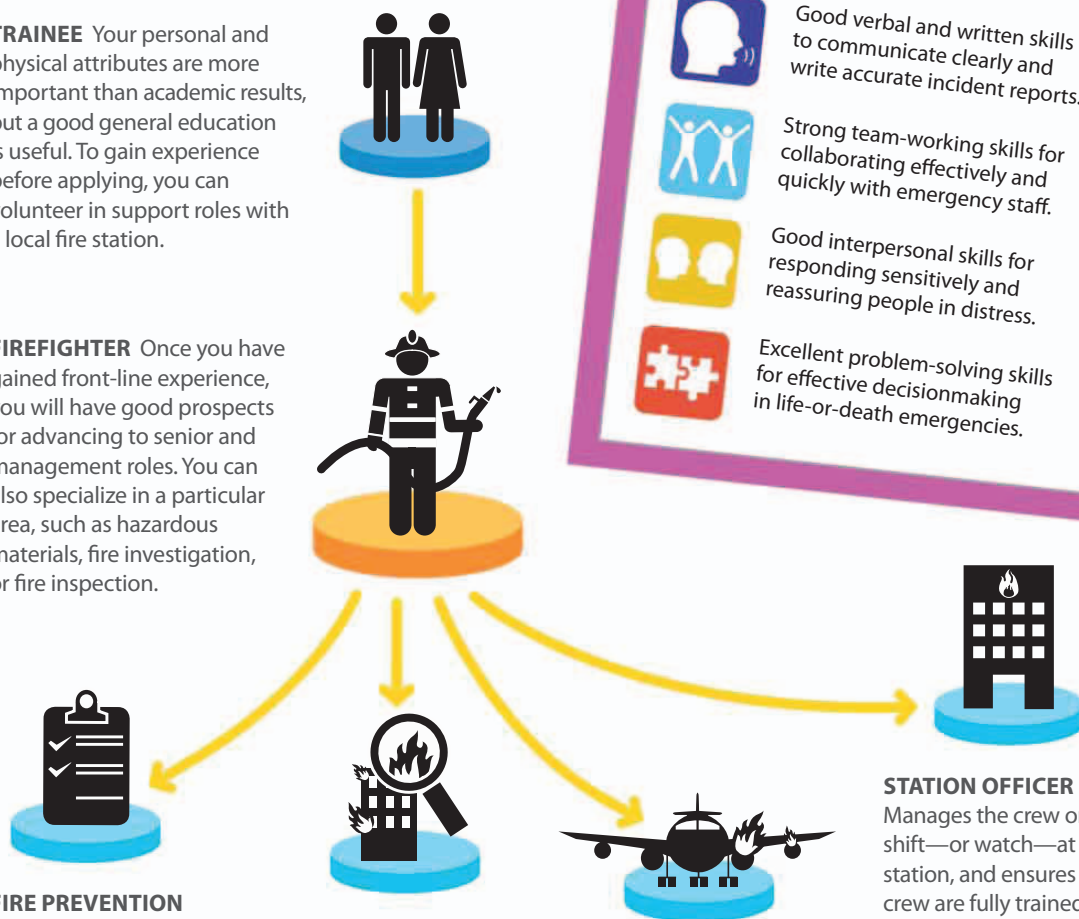
**FIREFIGHTER** Once you have gained front-line experience, you will have good prospects for advancing to senior and management roles. You can also specialize in a particular area, such as hazardous materials, fire investigation, or fire inspection.

**FIRE PREVENTION OFFICER** Visits homes and business premises to check that they are free from fire hazards and meet fire and safety regulations, such as having working fire alarms and extinguishers.

**FIRE INVESTIGATOR** Examines evidence at the scene of an incident to determine the causes of a fire, explosion, or other accident. Fire investigators are usually experienced former firefighters.

**AIRPORT FIREFIGHTER** Responds to aviation emergencies using specialty equipment, including suppressant foam for fighting aviation-fuel fires.

**STATION OFFICER** Manages the crew on shift—or watch—at a fire station, and ensures that crew are fully trained and firefighting equipment and vehicles are in a good condition. With experience, and after passing further exams, station officers can move up in rank, gaining additional responsibilities.



### SKILLS GUIDE



Physical strength and endurance to carry heavy equipment and injured or unconscious victims.



Good verbal and written skills to communicate clearly and write accurate incident reports.



Strong team-working skills for collaborating effectively and quickly with emergency staff.



Good interpersonal skills for responding sensitively and reassuring people in distress.



Excellent problem-solving skills for effective decisionmaking in life-or-death emergencies.